the last, the fifth, in 2015. The last survey reported labour force participation rate as 50.3 per cent, employment rate of 47.8 per cent and unemployment rate of 5.0 per cent.

These annual surveys were replaced in 2017 by the Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS), which was designed to estimate three key ratios of employment (worker-population ratio, labour force participation rate and unemployment rate) at an interval of three months in urban areas only. Employment status is measured on a daily, weekly and yearly basis. PLFS was intended to measure these three key ratios on a weekly basis. The ninth quarterly PLFS was released on 9 September 2021 for the quarter October–December 2020.

The Centre for Monitoring Indian Economy (CMIE) conducts regular labour surveys called the Consumer Pyramids Household Survey, or CPHS. There is a key difference between PLFS and CPHS. While PLFS uses the international definition of treating workers as employed even if they worked for an hour any day in the past seven days, CPHS uses a more stringent definition of employment: working for not less than three hours on the day of the survey.

CPHS is the only survey in India that brings out three key labour ratios on a regular basis every week: worker participation rate, employment rate and weekly unemployment rate. This data is also provided on a monthly, quarterly and yearly basis. In India, we do not have official employment data for the COVID-19 period even at the end of March 2020, whereas very comprehensive data sets are available from CMIE.

Labour Participation Rate Peaked in the 1970s

Data from the Second Labour Commission on the labour participation rate (LPR) until 2000 suggests that it was the highest in 1977–78 in both rural and urban areas. LPR for men in rural and urban areas was recorded at 56.5 per cent and 54.3 per cent respectively in 1977–78. For women, it was